

From Hormuz to East Asia: China's Exposure, Regional Crisis Risks, and Forecast-Based Scenarios

How the Hormuz-centred crisis is reshaping China's energy security, trade and strategic behaviour, and which regional actor China is most likely to enter a geopolitical crisis with over the coming year

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NERAI data as of	Country indices 13 Sep 2026; maritime corridors 14 Sep; corridor forecast ledger 13 Sep; Forecast Desk review 15 Sep; market layer 14 Sep; live chokepoint AIS and 24-h themes 1 Oct 2026	Open-source cutoff	30 Sep 2026	Forecast issue dates	Corridor ledger 13 Sep 2026; shock model 13 Sep 2026; Forecast Desk questions filed 27 Jul-17 Aug 2026, last re-scored 15 Sep 2026; SCS flashpoint projection issued 15 Sep for 20 Sep-11 Oct
Evidence labels	OBS NERAI observed data MOD NERAI model / forecast output PUB verified open source (dated) AJ analyst judgement N/A outside platform coverage				

A. Executive summary

HORMUZ TRANSIT (NERAI) -92.7% vs trailing baseline, SEVERE; 4.4 transits/day vs 59.8 baseline (14 Sep). Live AIS 1 Oct: 0 vessels in geofence sample.	CHINA SEABORNE CRUDE IMPORTS 7.14 mb/d August 2026, 37.4% below the Dec 2025-Feb 2026 baseline of 11.41 mb/d (PUB)	HIGHEST-PRIORITY CRISIS DYAD China-Philippines Philippines military-clash signal at 100th percentile, China at 99th; both at 18-month highs (13 Sep)	BASELINE OUTCOME Managed tension No NERAI model predicts a defined bilateral crisis event; serious escalation is less plausible than managed tension (AJ)
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China's most important exposures. The Strait of Hormuz has been closed or severely restricted since 28 February 2026 and remains SEVERE on every NERAI reading to the data cutoff; preliminary PortWatch data for 27-28 September show five and then zero transits (PUB). Before the crisis 45-50% of China's crude imports and about 30% of its LNG transited the strait (PUB). China has absorbed the shock through demand compression, inventory draws and Russian barrels rather than through alternative routes: seaborne crude imports ran 4.27 mb/d below the pre-war baseline in August, Russian seaborne imports rose to 1.68 mb/d, Iranian deliveries collapsed to a provisional 534 kb/d under the US blockade, and Brent stood at \$104-107 in the second half of September, roughly 60% above its pre-crisis level (PUB) (OBS). NERAI's market layer records Brent +17.5% over 30 days to 11 September. Chinese refiners have simultaneously increased distillate exports to 963 kb/d, which suggests price and policy matter alongside physical supply constraints (PUB).

Highest-priority crisis area and event type. The China-Philippines dyad in the South China Sea. NERAI's Philippines military-clash and military-escalation series are both at the 100th percentile of their own 18-month history and China's are at the 99th and 95th, with 90-day percentile moves of +84 and +72 points respectively (OBS). The 18 September ramming of the Philippine fisheries vessel *Magat Salamat* 54 nm off Palawan, the July Scarborough confrontations and Foreign Minister Wang Yi's 22 July warning of "bitter consequences" are the verified events behind the signal (PUB). The most plausible crisis form is a coast-guard-level incident producing casualties or a sustained blockade of a Philippine-held feature, followed by a diplomatic and economic-coercion crisis that tests the US-Philippines Mutual Defense Treaty. A military clash with armed forces engaged is plausible but not the modal outcome.

Escalation versus managed tension. Managed tension remains the baseline. No NERAI model produces a probability for a defined bilateral crisis event between China and any neighbour; the platform's calibrated shock probabilities describe jumps in news-derived risk series, and the Forecast Desk's open questions concern Hormuz, sanctions and export controls, not East Asian military events. The strongest structural argument against serious escalation is the command disruption involving Zhang Youxia and Liu Zhenli, investigated in January and expelled on 21 September. Some analysts see reduced joint-operation capacity and more rigid crisis management; both effects remain uncertain and unproven (PUB). The 24 September Trump-Xi summit, which advanced plans for military crisis communications and extended the trade truce, is a second restraining factor (PUB).

Most defensible time window. The 31-90-day window (1 November-30 December 2026) for a limited China-Philippines incident of the coast-guard type, because the signal series are at their highs now, the monsoon-season resupply cycle to Second Thomas Shoal and Scarborough continues, and the PLA command transition raises the chance of an unmanaged tactical incident. NERAI's 4-week shock probability for the Philippines military-clash series is 0.341 against a 0.324 platform base rate, that is, the model does not see an unusual jump risk on top of an already-elevated level; the level itself is the warning (MOD). For the Korean Peninsula and the Taiwan Strait the evidence supports watching rather than a time window.

Confidence and major uncertainties. Moderate confidence in the actor ranking (the Philippines signal is corroborated by dated incidents and by a second, related risk series set); low-to-moderate confidence in the time window (analyst judgement, no event model); low confidence in any causal attribution to Hormuz (see section F: the evidence points to Hormuz as a constraint and a diplomatic amplifier, not a driver, of East Asian tension). The largest uncertainties are the status of US-Iran talks after Trump's rejection of Iran's seven-day reopening proposal on 28 September and the operational consequences of the PLA purge.

B. Data and forecast inventory

WHAT THIS SECTION SETTLES	Which NERAI datasets and prediction outputs were actually accessible for this report, what each predicts, when it was issued, and what is missing. Nothing listed as N/A is used anywhere below.
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Module / dataset	Target variable and unit	Coverage	Issue / cutoff	Horizon	Output used here	Validation evidence and limitation
Country risk indices	Daily event-density series, 40 topics, as 30-day mean percentile vs each series' own history (0-100)	60 countries; Taiwan and Vietnam not covered	13 Sep 2026 (daily; series start 29 Mar 2025)	Descriptive	China, Philippines, Japan, South Korea, North Korea, India, Iran topic percentiles; 30/90-day changes; 18-month baselines	Relative, not absolute, risk; news-derived; a 100th percentile means "highest 30-day mean in 18 months", not "crisis imminent".
Shock probability model	P(series jumps ≥ 1 SD of its own weekly change within H weeks)	All 2,400 series	13 Sep 2026	4 / 9 / 13 / 26 weeks	4-week and 9-week shock_p for escalation topics of the six actors	Out-of-sample ECE 1.1% on 118,300 cases; 4-week top-decile precision 0.505 vs 0.318 base rate. It forecasts jumps in a news index, not conflict events; read against base rates 0.324 (4w), 0.566 (9w).
HMM regime model	Latent regime (Calm / Tension / Crisis), escalation probability to a worse regime next step, expected persistence	60 countries	13 Sep 2026 (model fit 6 Sep)	Next step	China Tension (esc. 0.20); Philippines Tension (0.17); S. Korea Calm (0.30); N. Korea Calm (0.22); Japan Calm (0.18); India Calm (0.14); Iran Crisis	Regimes are statistical states of an adverse-event composite; no event-level validation published on the platform.
Maritime corridors	Transit disruption % vs trailing baseline (PortWatch/AIS transits), status band, threat and activity scores	8 corridors	14 Sep 2026	Descriptive	Hormuz -92.7% SEVERE; Red Sea -20.1%; Malacca -11.1% STRAINED; South China Sea STRAINED; Taiwan Strait -1.0% NORMAL	Traffic index, not tonnage; "9 of 10 chokepoints normal" corroboration shows single-corridor collapse, not a feed outage.
Corridor forecast ledger	P(additional disruption event) per corridor, cumulative	8 corridors	13 Sep 2026 (ledger since 2 Jul)	2 / 4 / 8 weeks	Hormuz 13.8 / 43.8 / 72.3%; Taiwan Strait 12.8 / 47.4 / 75.6%; SCS 13.8 / 47.4 / 75.6%; Malacca 10.3 / 42.6 / 70.9%; p(JWC listing change 6w) Hormuz 0.23	Not the probability that the current state persists. Corridor-level probabilities describe transit-disruption events and are not used here as political-crisis probabilities.
Forecast Desk	Binary questions with calibrated probability, re-scored every 2 days	32 open questions	Filed 27 Jul-17 Aug; last review 15 Sep 2026	To 31 Mar 2027 - 30 Jun 2028	US-Iran formal ceasefire by 31 Mar 2027: 3%; Lloyd's JWC Hormuz listing: 91%; carrier Hormuz surcharge formalised: 86%; China critical-mineral controls expand: 80%; CXMT Entity List: 68%; Hengli 69%: historical only; 24 Apr; US-ROK drill reduction: 39%	No open question on Taiwan, the South China Sea, Japan-China, India-China or a Korean military event.

Flashpoint monitor - "South China Sea / Taiwan"	Escalation share of dyad coverage (raw 0-1) with 3-week projection	CN-PH, US-CN, CN-MY dyads	Issued 15 Sep for 20 Sep-11 Oct	3 weeks	Current 0.0108; projected 0.0130 (interval 0.0066-0.0194), direction rising; CN-PH dyad score 14.9 (+13), US-CN 18.8 (-10)	A news-share projection, not an incident probability.
Live chokepoint AIS	Vessels in geofence, terrestrial sample	10 chokepoints	1 Oct 2026 05:43 UTC	Live	Hormuz 0, Bab el-Mandeb 0, Taiwan Strait 24, Malacca 15	A floor, not a census; a zero means none observed in the sample.
Market layer	Benchmark prices, 7/30-day change	18 series	11-14 Sep 2026	Descriptive	Brent \$104.61 (+17.5% 30d), WTI \$100.05, gold \$4,409, USD/CNY 6.71, 10Y UST 4.97%	Yahoo-derived; used as context only.
TradeControl / sanctions	Register diffs, enforcement actions	UK, US, EU	13 Sep 2026	Descriptive	Iran-related UK guidance updates; OFAC SDN 19,369 entries; 250 live changes	Used for the China-Iran energy channel only.
Supply-chain layer	GSCPI, chokepoint transits, disruption forecast board	Global	GSCPI Jul 2026; transits 6 Sep	-	GSCPI 0.805 SD (88th pct), down from 1.84 in Apr	Monthly series, restated at each release; used as context.
Scope note	Taiwan and Vietnam are assessed through the corridor, flashpoint and open-source layers rather than country series. No NERAI model predicts a defined bilateral military event; where such a probability would be needed the report gives a labelled analyst judgement instead of a number.					

C. The Hormuz crisis at the cutoff and its transmission to China

What constitutes the crisis

Verified sequence **PUB**: US and Israeli strikes on Iran from 28 February 2026 and Iran's closure of the strait to "unfriendly" shipping (2-4 March); a US aerial campaign from 19 March; a US naval blockade of Iranian ports from 12-15 April; US "Project Freedom" escorts for stranded ships in May; a US-Iran memorandum signed 14-17 June that lifted the blockade on 18 June and briefly lifted transits to about 20 per day (roughly one-third of the report's 59.8/day baseline); and a breakdown of that interim agreement "shortly after it was announced", with Iran's parliament speaker stating on 20 September that the strait "will remain closed until the US meets its commitments". By late September the IMO-tracked toll since February stood at 86 incidents and 24 seafarer deaths; 461 AIS-visible vessels were holding off berth in the strait area on 20 September; two tankers were struck by projectiles on 29 September; and President Trump rejected Iran's seven-day reopening proposal on 28 September while Qatar continued mediation. This is therefore a sustained closure with intermittent, Iran-approved passage, not a temporary restriction. NERAI's reading is consistent: the transit index has been SEVERE on every snapshot since July, at 4.4 transits/day against a 59.8 baseline on 14 September **OBS**, and the Forecast Desk prices a formal US-Iran ceasefire by 31 March 2027 at 3% (down 28 points since filing on 27 July) **MOD**.

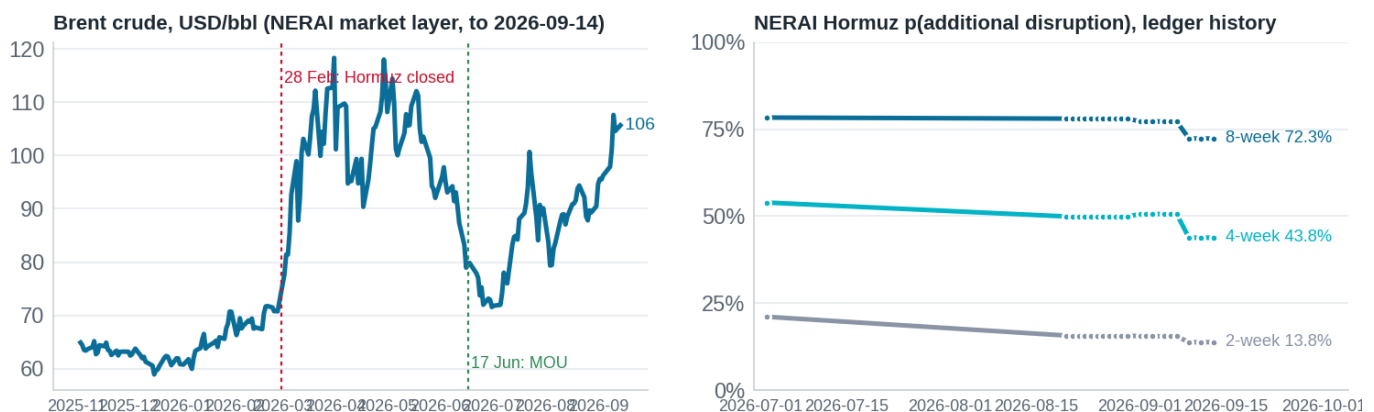


Figure 1. Left: Brent in NERAI's market layer, Nov 2025 to 14 Sep 2026, with the closure and MOU dates marked (OBS). Right: NERAI corridor-ledger probability of an additional Hormuz disruption event at 2/4/8 weeks, 2 Jul to 13 Sep 2026 (MOD). The forecast has eased 10 points at 4 weeks since July while the observed state remains severe - the model prices new disruption events, not persistence.

Transmission channels

Channel	Observed impact	NERAI signal	Analyst inference
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Oil supply and routes	Seaborne crude imports 7.14 mb/d in Aug (Jul 6.93), 37.4% below the Dec 2025-Feb 2026 baseline; Russian seaborne 1.68 mb/d plus ~1 mb/d pipeline; Iranian crude to China fell from ~1.4 mb/d (2025) to 785 kb/d (Jun), 823 (Jul), provisional 534 (Aug) under the blockade; Iranian tankers still conducting STS transfers off Zhuhai and Hong Kong on 17 and 22 Sep. About 30 Chinese vessels received Iran-coordinated passage in May; Iran blocked two Chinese ships on 27 Mar. Saudi East-West pipeline reopened late Sep after Houthi damage. PUB	Hormuz -92.7% SEVERE; Red Sea -20.1% DISRUPTED; Malacca -11.1% STRAINED (Chinese import leg). Forecast Hengli: already listed 24 Apr; 69% historical only OBS MOD	China is running a managed-shortage strategy: inventory draw from a reserve reported at 1.39 bn bbl (120 days of net imports), demand compression and Russian substitution. The Iran-approved corridor gives Beijing a privileged but politically costly channel; the US blockade, not Iranian policy, is what cut Iranian barrels. AJ
LNG and power	~30% of China's LNG transited Hormuz pre-crisis (Qatar, UAE). LNG demand in China and India "depressed in recent months" by price (OilPrice, 1 Oct theme layer). EU storage <80% by 1 Nov priced at 57% by NERAI. PUB MOD	Natural gas (US Henry Hub) \$2.83, +2.6% 30d: the squeeze is in Asian spot LNG, where the price pressure sits AJ	Coal-fired dispatch and industrial demand management are absorbing the LNG gap; the effect is a cost and emissions problem, not a security-of-supply problem within the 12-month horizon. AJ
Prices and inventories	Brent \$104.61 on 11 Sep (+17.5% 30d), \$107.30 on 28 Sep; peak above \$118 in April. China drew crude inventories in August as refinery runs rose; distillate exports 963 kb/d (pre-war 713). OBS PUB	Brent 30-day change +17.5%; gold +7.5%; USD/CNY 6.71 (-0.7%), i.e. no yuan stress OBS	Macro-financial transmission to China is muted; the burden falls on refining margins and fiscal fuel-price management. AJ
Shipping, insurance, delivery times	Forecast Desk: Lloyd's JWC Hormuz listing 91%; ≥3 top-5 carriers formalising a ≥\$1,000/TEU Hormuz surcharge 86%; p(JWC listed-area change, 6w) 0.23. Stranded vessels ~1,000 at peak. MOD PUB	Container cost pressure 65.4 (Hormuz), 57.7 (Malacca), 54.1 (SCS) OBS	Gulf-China liner and tanker economics are structurally repriced for at least two quarters; Malacca strain is cost-driven (bunker), not security-driven. AJ
Manufacturing and critical inputs	China's rare-earth suppliers halted US shipments; Forecast Desk prices expansion of China's critical-mineral export controls at 80% (Sep 2027) and a US DoD non-Chinese sourcing mandate at 70%. Busan rare-earth compromise continued at the 24 Sep summit. MOD PUB	China "international support" 96th pctl; "increasing bilateral relations" collapsed 95 → 14 OBS	Energy stress has not weakened China's hand in mineral leverage; if anything it has hardened mercantilist behaviour. AJ
Relations with Iran, Gulf, US, partners	China and Russia vetoed force authorisation (7 Apr); China vetoed renewal of nuclear-sanctions monitoring (Sep); Wang Yi's 30+ calls; MOFCOM blocking order (2 May) against US sanctions on five Chinese oil buyers; ~60 Iran-linked designations incl. Hengli and teapot refiners; reported MANPADS and satellite support to Iran (Reuters, FT). Trump pressed Xi on 24 Sep to isolate Iran; Xi urged return to the June interim deal; no breakthrough. PUB	Iran "deteriorating bilateral relations" 100th pctl; UAE regime Crisis; Saudi military de-escalation 95th pctl OBS	Hormuz has made China an indispensable but distrusted broker: it is the only major importer with a working Iranian channel, which raises its diplomatic value to Washington and the Gulf while exposing Chinese entities to secondary sanctions. AJ
Room for manoeuvre	Growth downgrade risk flagged by CSIS in April; by June analysts argued China was the relative beneficiary (reserves, renewables, price influence). Taiwan LNG-vulnerability disinformation campaign in March. PUB	China regime Tension, escalation prob 0.20; instability and political-repression series at 100th pctl OBS	The domestic-stability signals (instability, repression, ethnic-religious violence all at 99-100) are a stronger constraint on external adventurism than the energy shock itself. AJ

Separating Hormuz effects from pre-existing pressures

China's export-control escalation, the Japan pressure campaign (since November 2025), the South China Sea ramming pattern (since at least the 11 August 2025 Scarborough collision) and the PLA leadership purge all pre-date or run independently of the Hormuz closure. The Hormuz-specific effects are confined to energy volumes and prices, Gulf shipping economics, secondary-sanctions exposure of Chinese refiners and traders, and China's elevated diplomatic standing with Tehran and Washington. AJ

D. Regional screening and prioritisation

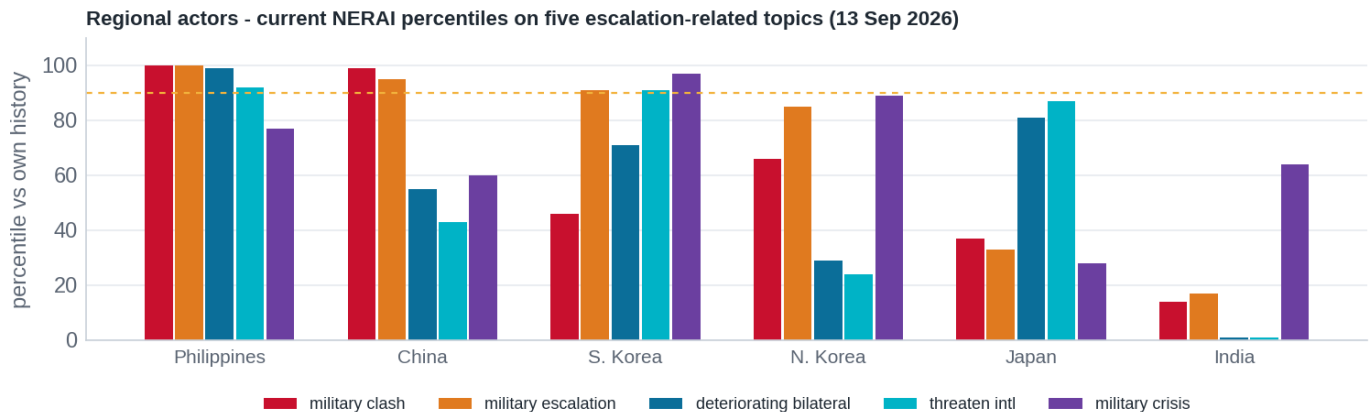


Figure 2. Current NERAI percentiles (30-day mean vs own 18-month history) on five escalation-related topics for six regional actors, 13 Sep 2026 (OBS). Taiwan and Vietnam are not NERAI countries and are assessed from the Taiwan Strait corridor, the "South China Sea / Taiwan" flashpoint and open sources.

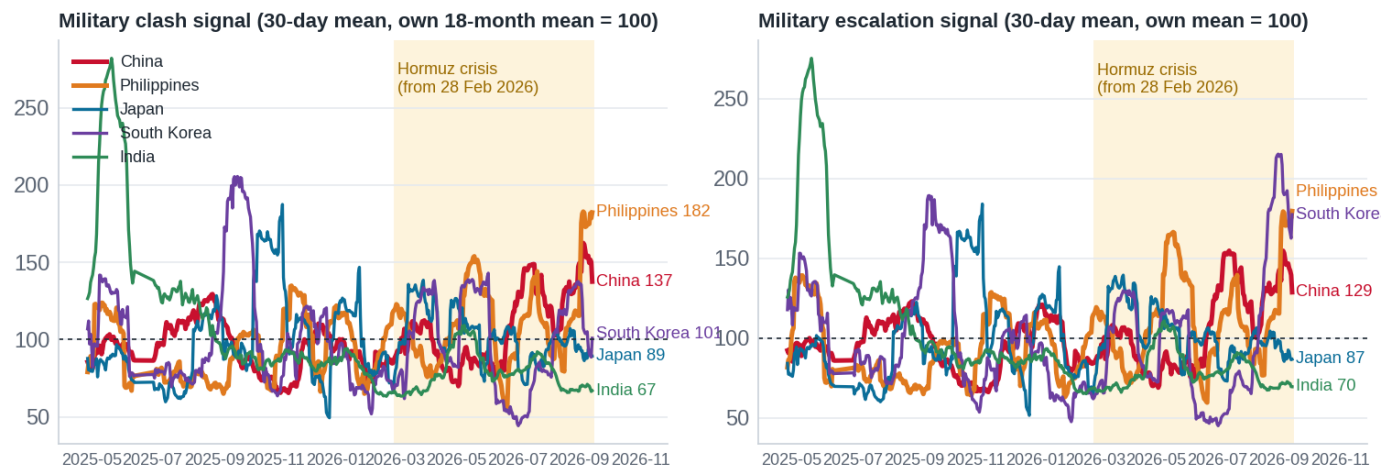


Figure 3. 30-day rolling mean of the military-clash and military-escalation series, indexed to each series' own 18-month mean (= 100), 29 Mar 2025 to 14 Sep 2026 (OBS). The Philippines and China series are at or near their highest readings of the period; India's May 2025 spike (India-Pakistan) shows what a genuine inter-state crisis looks like in this data; the Hormuz period is shaded.

Actor	Crisis type most consistent with evidence	Current tension (verified)	NERAI prediction / signal	Time window	Trigger	Restraining factor	Confidence
Philippines (SCS)	Coast-guard clash with casualties or blockade of a Philippine-held feature; MDT test	18 Sep CCG ramming off Palawan; 23 Jul Scarborough expulsions after Wang Yi's 22 Jul warning; Aug 2025 PLAN-CCG collision with deaths	military_clash 100 (90d: 15), military_escalation 100 (21), deteriorating relations 99; shock_p 4w 0.341 / 9w 0.658 (base 0.324 / 0.566); regime Tension, esc. 0.17; CN-PH flashpoint dyad +13; SCS escalation share projected rising to 11 Oct OBS	31-90 days for a limited incident; 6-12 months for a blockade-type crisis	Fatal ramming; resupply standoff at Second Thomas or Scarborough; Philippine joint patrol with US assets	US MDT and warship presence; Trump-Xi mil-mil channel; Chinese preference for grey-zone over kinetic	MODERATE on actor; LOW-MOD on window

MOD

Taiwan Strait	Large-scale exercise or quarantine-style coercion; incident with coast guard near Kinmen	Aug ADIZ incursions 125, under half of 2024/2025 levels; record 244 PRC vessels in Jul; routine 2-7 aircraft / 6 ships daily in Sep; 21 Sep formal expulsion; Xi asked Trump on 24 Sep to "oppose" independence; \$14 bn arms package delayed	Taiwan Strait corridor NORMAL (-1.0%); live AIS 24 vessels; ledger p(transit disruption) 4w 47.4%, 8w 75.6% (transit risk, not a crisis probability); assessed via corridor and flashpoint layers OBS MOD	No evidence-based window inside 12 months for major crisis; coercive exercises possible around Nov local elections / nuclear referendum	Taiwan election outcome; US arms decision; a Kinmen coast-guard incident	PLA command hollowing; US-China summitry; declining ADIZ activity trend	LOW for escalation; MODERATE that 2026 stays below 2024-25 pressure levels
Korean Peninsula	Inter-Korean border incident; missile-test cycle; China as external actor, not party	21 Sep DMZ mine detonation injuring ROK soldier; 22 Sep extended-range 240 mm test; 24-29 Sep DPRK "irreversible" nuclear statements; 29 Sep ROK nuclear-submarine bill	S. Korea military_crisis 97 (90d: 1), military_escalation 91 (5); N. Korea military_escalation 85 (4), military_crisis 89 (13); shock_p 4w 0.553 (KS escalation), the highest in the set; regimes Calm; US-ROK drill-reduction directive 39% OBS MOD	0-90 days for incidents; not a China crisis	Casualty-producing DMZ incident; US-DPRK summit collapse	Trump-Kim channel; Chinese interest in stability; ROK restraint	MODERATE that tension rises; HIGH that it is not a China-ROK/DPRK crisis
Japan (ECS)	Diplomatic and economic coercion continuing; low-probability air/sea incident near Senkaku or Okinawa	Rare-earth (Tb, Dy) exports to Japan at zero since Nov 2025; flight cancellations 30%; Jul live-fire near Okinotori; Jun carrier incident claim; Sep parliamentary visits; official talks frozen pending Takaichi retraction	deteriorating relations 81 (90d: 6), threaten 87 (21), but military_clash 37 (falling) and military_crisis 28; shock_p 4w 0.536 on deteriorating relations OBS MOD	Coercion persists 6-12 months; incident window not supported	Takaichi statement; Senkaku intrusion with Japanese casualties; Taiwan contingency	Economic interdependence; US alliance; both sides' signalling via parliamentarians	MODERATE for continued coercion; LOW for military incident
India (LAC)	Border incident	13 Sep Modi-Xi meeting in New Delhi (BRICS), first Xi visit since 2019; both pledge border peace; readouts differ	military_clash 14, escalation 17, deteriorating relations 1 (all falling); international_crisis 87 but flat and driven by Pakistan/Iran coverage OBS	None supported	LAC patrol incident; Pakistan-linked crisis spill-over	Active leader-level thaw; shared energy-import interest	HIGH that India is not the priority dyad
Vietnam / Malaysia / Indonesia (SCS)	Fisheries or survey-vessel confrontation	DPRK-Vietnam defence delegation 25-28 Sep; no major CN-VN incident verified in Sep	Indonesia military_clash 96 and escalation 96 (both +66-72 in 90 d), deteriorating relations 98; Malaysia military_crisis 86; CN-MY dyad falling (-30); Vietnam not covered OBS N/A	Watch	Natuna / Luconia Shoals standoff	ASEAN-China diplomacy; Indonesia's hedging	LOW ; Indonesia signal needs event verification before it is promoted

Screening result

Priority areas carried forward: (1) China-Philippines in the South China Sea, (2) the Taiwan Strait, (3) the Korean Peninsula as a regional escalation theatre in which China is an external stabiliser rather than a party, and (4) China-Japan as a coercion case. India is screened out. Indonesia's signal is noted as the one unexpected riser and is placed on the watchlist pending verification of a specific incident. **AJ**

E. Crisis event definitions

Event class	Observable criteria for "has occurred" (applied to every scenario below)
1. Diplomatic confrontation / economic coercion	Formal protest at ministerial level plus at least one of: ambassador summoned or recalled, new trade or travel restriction gazetted, named sanctions on the counterpart's entities. Ongoing for China-Japan since Nov 2025.
2. Limited maritime or land incident	Physical contact (ramming, water cannon, laser, warning shots) or detention of personnel between state vessels or forces, without fatalities, acknowledged by at least one government. Occurred CN-PH 18 Sep 2026.

3. Clash involving coastguard or military forces with casualties	Death or serious injury of state personnel attributed to the counterpart's action, or exchange of fire. Not occurred CN-PH in 2026 (Aug 2025 deaths were Chinese-on-Chinese).
4. Blockade, quarantine or substantial transport restriction	Declared or de facto denial of resupply or transit to a feature, port or island for ≥ 7 consecutive days, verified by the affected state and independent AIS/imagery; or NERAI corridor transit deviation worse than -25% for 7 days on the Taiwan Strait or SCS corridor.
5. Prolonged military crisis	Class 3 or 4 sustained ≥ 14 days with mobilisation or deployment announcements by both sides and alliance consultations formally invoked (e.g., MDT Article III consultations, NATO-style Article 4 analogues).
6. Large-scale armed conflict	Sustained combat between regular forces with ≥ 100 battle deaths in a month (NERAI operational threshold, not UCDP's war definition, which requires $\geq 1,000$ battle-related deaths in a calendar year).

An isolated class-2 incident does not constitute escalation; a scenario is only "serious escalation" when class 3 or above is met and sustained.

F. Prediction evidence by priority area and the Hormuz causal test

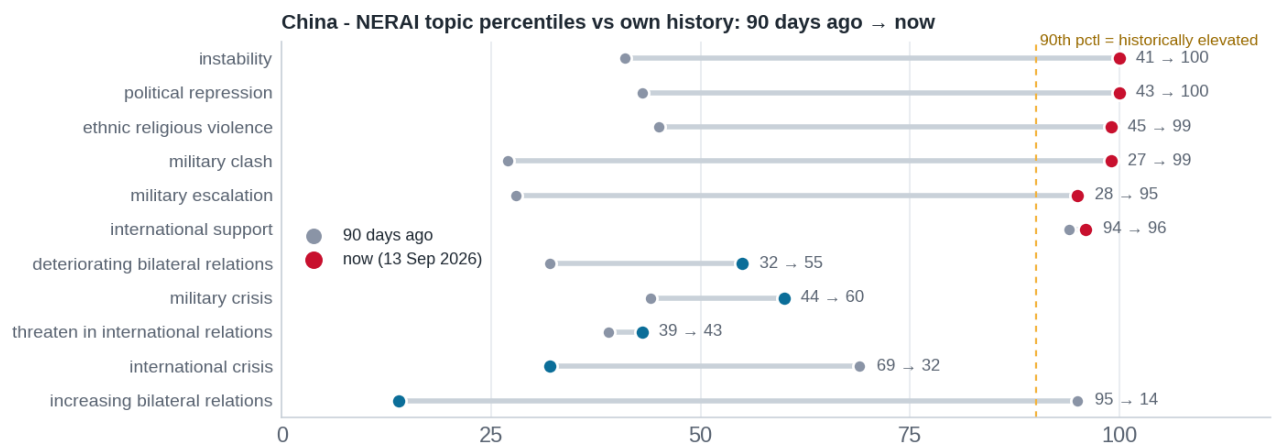


Figure 4. China's NERAI topic percentiles, 90 days ago versus 13 Sep 2026 (OBS). The externally relevant movers (military clash +72, military escalation +67) coincide with a collapse in "increasing bilateral relations" (95 → 14) and an "international crisis" series that has fallen (69 → 32); the domestic-stability topics have moved to the top of the distribution.

F.1 China-Philippines, South China Sea

Forecast series and latest updates. The Philippines military-clash 30-day mean reached its 18-month high on 5 September and the military-escalation series its high on 14 September; both are 2.7-2.8 times their level 90 days earlier and 1.8 times their 18-month mean. China's military-clash series peaked on 5 September at 1.7x its 90-day-earlier level. The shock model gives the Philippines series a 4-week jump probability of 0.341 (4w; base 0.324) and 0.658 (9w; base 0.566): +1.7 and +9.2 percentage points. Neither measures persistence.

MOD. The HMM regime for both countries is Tension with next-step escalation probabilities of 0.17-0.20; neither is in Crisis **MOD**. The flashpoint monitor's CN-PH dyad rose 13 points while the US-CN dyad fell 10, and its escalation-share projection for 20 Sep-11 Oct is rising (0.0108 → 0.0130) **MOD**.

What each forecast predicts. The percentiles and shock probabilities predict the intensity of adverse-event reporting about each country, not bilateral conflict. The dyad score is a share of coverage. None of these is a probability of a class-3 event.

Comparison with verified events. The signal matches the record: 18 September ramming within 10 minutes of interception 54 nm off Palawan (Philippine Coast Guard statement; Chinese spokesperson blaming Manila), the 23 July Scarborough expulsions one day after Wang Yi's warning, and the pattern since the 11 August 2025 collision in which a PLAN warship struck a CCG cutter while pursuing BRP Suluan **PUB**. Supporting evidence for a higher-risk reading: Philippine officials weighing joint US patrols and resupply; the Scarborough "nature reserve" declaration. Contradicting evidence: no fatalities in any 2026 CN-PH incident; the US-CN dyad is cooling after the summit; Beijing's economic ties with Manila are intact.

Do the forecasts change the assessment? Yes, in one respect: without NERAI the Palawan incident would read as another routine grey-zone episode; the series show that the frequency and intensity of such episodes are at an 18-month maximum for both parties simultaneously, which is a warning context for monitoring casualty-producing incidents, rather than a validated causal relationship. They do not support a probability figure for class 3.

Hormuz causal test - Philippines

Mechanism A (energy pressure → restraint): weak support; China's SCS behaviour intensified through the crisis, not the reverse. Mechanism B (pressure → assertiveness in specific areas): partial support; Beijing has used the period of US distraction in the Gulf to normalise harder CCG tactics, but the escalation began in August 2025, before Hormuz. Mechanism C (US attention diverted → perceived opportunity): the strongest of the three; US naval assets were committed to Gulf escort and blockade duty from March to June, and NATO allies declined to join, which lowers the expected cost of SCS coercion. Counterfactual: the CN-PH tension would very likely have developed without the Hormuz shock. Verdict: Hormuz is an **amplifier** through the US-attention channel, not a driver. **AJ**

F.2 Taiwan Strait

NERAI holds no Taiwan country series. The corridor layer shows transit NORMAL (-1.0%) and the live sample 24 vessels on 1 October OBS ; the corridor ledger's Taiwan Strait figures describe transit-disruption risk and are not read as a political-crisis probability. The verified picture is of declining aerial pressure (125 ADIZ incursions in August, under half of 2024 and 2025), record grey-zone vessel presence (244 in July), routine daily activity in September (2-7 aircraft, 6 PLAN ships), 21 September expulsions following January investigations of two senior operational commanders from the CMC, and a 24 September summit at which Xi pressed on independence language and Trump declined to concede while keeping a \$14 bn arms package delayed PUB . Outside analysis (Modern Diplomacy, 30 Sep) suggests reduced invasion capacity and more rigid crisis management; operational effects remain uncertain. Hormuz link: China's March disinformation tying Taiwan's LNG vulnerability to "peaceful unification" is the only documented connection; it is a narrative, not an operational, channel. Verdict: Hormuz is **largely unrelated** operationally and a minor narrative amplifier. AJ

F.3 Korean Peninsula

South Korea's military-crisis series jumped from the 1st to the 97th percentile in 90 days, a 17-fold rise in the 30-day mean, and North Korea's military-escalation series from the 4th to the 85th; South Korea's 4-week shock probability on military escalation (0.553) is the highest in the regional set OBS MOD . These readings preceded, rather than predicted, the 21 September DMZ mine injury, the 22 September rocket test and the DPRK's 24-29 September nuclear statements PUB , so the signal has event support. However, this is a peninsula dynamic in which China is an external stabiliser; no NERAI series or verified event indicates a China-DPRK or China-ROK confrontation, and the Forecast Desk's only Korea question (US-ROK drill reduction, 39%) concerns alliance posture. Hormuz link: none demonstrated; the DPRK's Vietnam defence outreach and nuclear rhetoric track the Trump-Kim channel and ROK politics. Verdict: **unrelated** to Hormuz; relevant to China only as a constraint on its bandwidth. AJ

F.4 China-Japan

Japan's deteriorating-relations series rose from the 6th to the 81st percentile and its threat series from the 21st to the 87th, while its military-clash and military-crisis series fell (37 and 28); the 4-week shock probability on deteriorating relations is 0.536 OBS MOD . This is the profile of a coercion crisis, not a military one, and it matches the record: zero terbium and dysprosium oxide exports to Japan since November 2025, ~30% cancellation of mainland-Japan flights through August, a complete Japanese-film ban at the Shanghai festival, July live-fire near Okinotori, frozen official talks, and September parliamentarian visits that Beijing used to restate its condition that Takaichi retract her Taiwan remarks PUB . Hormuz link: Japan declined to join the Hormuz coalition in March and is itself an LNG importer exposed to the Gulf; the energy shock has, if anything, encouraged Japanese hedging rather than confrontation. Verdict: Hormuz is **unrelated** to the China-Japan crisis, which is a class-1 event already under way. AJ

F.5 Validation evidence

The only NERAI prediction with a published validation record is the shock model: out-of-sample expected calibration error 1.1% on 118,300 cases, top-decile precision 0.505 at 4 weeks against a 0.318 base rate, 0.778 at 9 weeks against 0.554, isotonic-calibrated on a time-based split MOD . This validates the model's claim about jumps in its own series; it says nothing about conflict events. Forecast Desk questions and corridor-ledger entries resolve against named external authorities at their horizons; Brier scores accrue as questions resolve. MASE or directional accuracy figures from other NERAI modules are not used here as evidence of calibrated conflict probability. Base rates matter: a 0.34 4-week shock probability is a base-rate reading, and the Philippines case is elevated on *level*, not on jump risk.

G. Conditional scenarios and time windows

Window	Model support available	Assessment
0-30 days (to 31 Oct)	Corridor ledger 2-4 wk; shock model 4 wk; flashpoint projection to 11 Oct; Forecast Desk open questions MOD	Hormuz: closure persists; p(additional disruption 2w) 13.8%, carrier surcharges and JWC listing on track (86%, 91%). SCS: continued class-2 incidents likely during resupply cycles; escalation share rising. Korea: incident cycle continues. Taiwan: routine pressure ahead of November votes. AJ
31-90 days (Nov-Dec 2026 to 30 Dec)	Shock model 9-13 wk; ledger 8 wk (72% additional-disruption probability on Hormuz) MOD	The most defensible window for a China-Philippines class-3 incident (casualties) if class-2 frequency stays at current highs; a US-Iran interim arrangement is possible but a formal ceasefire is priced at 3% by Mar 2027; Taiwan local elections and nuclear referendum in November are the Strait's main political trigger. AJ
3-6 months (to end-Mar to 30 Dec)	Shock model 26 wk (0.92-0.96 for most escalation series, i.e. uninformative); Forecast Desk horizons 31 Mar 2027 MOD	Conditional only: a class-4 SCS blockade crisis becomes plausible if a class-3 incident occurs and Manila moves to joint US resupply; China-Japan coercion persists unless Takaichi's position changes; APEC (China) leader meeting is a restraint. AJ
6-12 months (to Sep to 30 Dec)	No validated NERAI horizon; Forecast Desk questions to Jun-Sep 2027 (critical-mineral controls 80%, CXMT 68%) MOD	Structural: China's mercantilist leverage hardens regardless of Hormuz; PLA command reconstitution determines whether 2027 brings a demonstrative Taiwan exercise rather than a crisis; US midterms (Nov 2026) and G20 Miami are policy pivots. AJ

Scenario	Initial conditions	Triggers	Likely actor responses	Restraining / deterrent factors	Plausible window and basis	Strengthening indicators / invalidating developments
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S1. Managed tension (baseline)	Class-2 incidents continue CN-PH; Taiwan pressure below 2024-25 levels; Korea incident cycle; Japan coercion frozen; Hormuz SEVERE	None beyond routine resupply, patrols, exercises	Protests, coast-guard shadowing, US presence operations, summit-track diplomacy (APEC, G20), mil-mil channel use	PLA command hollowing; Trump-Xi truce; Chinese domestic-stability priorities (instability 100th pctl); Gulf energy constraint on Beijing's bandwidth	Entire 12 months; basis: no model predicts a defined event; shock probabilities at base rate	Strengthens: Philippines series falling back below 80th pctl; mil-mil hotline exercised after an incident. Weakens: a casualty incident; CN-PH dyad score >25.
S2. Limited crisis (CN-PH class 3)	Philippines and China clash series at 18-month highs; CCG ramming tempo up; possible command rigidity	Fatal or serious-injury ramming; detention of Philippine personnel; standoff at Second Thomas resupply	Manila invokes MDT consultations and requests US escort; Washington deploys destroyers (as Aug 2025); Beijing blames Manila, surges CCG and maritime militia, applies trade pressure (fruit, tourism); ASEAN statement; Japan/Australia support Manila	US MDT clarity (attacks on public vessels covered); Chinese preference to avoid a US naval engagement; summit calendar	31-90 days most defensible, extending to 6 months; basis: level of signal plus verified incident tempo, analyst judgement	Strengthens: second ramming within 30 days; CCG use of water cannon on crewed decks; Philippine joint-patrol announcement. Weakens: resumption of CN-PH bilateral consultative mechanism; de-escalatory Chinese MFA language; series fall below 70th pctl.
S3. Serious escalation (class 4-5)	S2 occurred and was not contained within 14 days	Chinese quarantine of a Philippine-held feature; US-escorted resupply challenged; exchange of fire	MDT Article III consultations; US and Philippine joint operations; Chinese naval deployment and declared exclusion zone; Japan and Australia logistical support; Beijing seeks Hormuz-style bargaining with Washington	Nuclear-power caution on both sides; PLA leadership gap; economic exposure of China already stressed by energy prices; Xi's APEC hosting	Not inside 90 days on current evidence; conditional 3-12 months; no model support	Strengthens: PLAN (not CCG) vessels in contact incidents; NERAI SCS corridor transit worse than -25% for 7 days; Chinese military-crisis series above 90th pctl. Weakens: Trump-Xi crisis-management mechanism operational; MDT consultation producing a de-confliction protocol.
S4. Taiwan coercive exercise	November Taiwan local elections and nuclear referendum; delayed US arms package decision	Election outcome Beijing dislikes; US arms approval; Taiwan leadership statements	Joint Sword-type exercise (2024A precedent: 62 aircraft, dozens of ships); coast-guard "law enforcement" patrols; US transit; Japan statements that re-ignite the China-Japan dispute	Purge-reduced joint-operations capacity; summit track; declining ADIZ trend	Nov 2026-Mar 2027, conditional; no NERAI Taiwan model	Strengthens: Taiwan Strait corridor transit deviation below -10%; live AIS cargo counts falling; Chinese military-escalation series re-rising above 95. Weakens: arms package approved without a Chinese military response; exercise scale below 2024-25.

Reading the scenarios together

The most likely crisis scenario (S2, a limited China-Philippines incident with casualties) is not the most likely overall outcome: S1 remains the baseline for all four areas. No precise date is offered; the 31-90-day window for S2 rests on the level and tempo of verified incidents and on NERAI's series being at their maxima, not on an event-probability model. AJ

H. Early-warning watchlist

Indicator	Source	Update	Meaningful change or threshold	Scenario supported
Philippines and China military_clash / military_escalation percentiles	NERAI country indices OBS	Daily	Model-defined band: ≥ 90 = historically elevated (current 99-100). Analyst-proposed: a fall below 70 for 14 days signals S1 consolidation; a renewed 30-day mean above the 5 Sep peak alongside a verified incident signals S2.	S1 / S2
Philippines military_clash shock probability (4 wk)	NERAI shock model MOD	Daily	Model-defined: compare with 0.324 base rate; analyst-proposed alert if > 0.45 (top-decile territory where precision is 0.505).	S2
"South China Sea / Taiwan" flashpoint - CN-PH dyad score and escalation share	NERAI flashpoint monitor MOD	Daily; 3-week projection	Analyst-proposed: dyad score > 25 (now 14.9) or escalation share above the projection's upper interval 0.0194.	S2 / S3
SCS and Taiwan Strait corridor transit deviation	NERAI maritime corridors OBS	Daily	Model-defined bands: STRAINED below -5%, DISRUPTED below -20%; analyst-proposed class-4 criterion: worse than -25% for 7 consecutive days.	S3 / S4
Live AIS counts, Taiwan Strait and Malacca	NERAI chokepoint AIS OBS	~12-hourly	Analyst-proposed: Taiwan Strait sample falling below 10 on two consecutive samples (now 24), noting floor-not-census caveat.	S4
Verified incident log: CCG/PLAN contact with Philippine vessels	PCG, AFP, USNI, AMTI PUB	Event-driven	Class-3 criterion (casualties or fire) = S2 occurred; two class-2 incidents within 30 days = S2 strengthening.	S2 / S3
US-Philippines MDT consultations / joint resupply announcement	DFA, State Dept, INDOPACOM PUB	Event-driven	Formal Article III consultation request or announced joint resupply = S3 pathway open.	S3
Hormuz transit deviation and p(additional disruption)	NERAI corridors and ledger OBS MOD	Daily / 2-daily	Model-defined: recovery above -50% for 10 consecutive days = sustained reopening; analyst-proposed: 4-week p falling below 30% with observed recovery = energy-channel relief for China.	Transmission to China (all)
Forecast Desk: US-Iran ceasefire (3%), JWC listing (91%) Hengli historical (69% already listed)	NERAI Forecast Desk MOD	Every 2 days	Model-defined: a move ≥ 3 pp carries a cited reason; analyst-proposed: ceasefire question above 15% signals a reopening path.	Transmission / S1
China seaborne crude imports and Iranian STS activity off Zhuhai / Hong Kong	Customs data, Kpler/Reuters, UANI shipping updates PUB	Monthly / weekly	Analyst-proposed: imports back above 9 mb/d = inventory rebuild phase; new OFAC designations of Chinese ports or refiners = sanctions-channel escalation.	Transmission
Taiwan ADIZ incursions and PRC vessel counts	Taiwan MND daily report PUB	Daily	Analyst-proposed: a month above 250 incursions (Aug 2026: 125) or a named joint exercise = S4.	S4
PLA command reconstitution	CMC announcements, Xinhua PUB	Event-driven	Appointment of a new CMC vice-chairman with joint-operations background = restored capacity for S4; continued vacancy = rigidity risk for S2.	S2 / S4
South Korea military_crisis / DPRK military_escalation percentiles	NERAI indices OBS	Daily	Model band ≥ 90 (now 97 / 85); analyst-proposed: a casualty-producing DMZ incident shifts this from watch to China-bandwidth constraint.	Context
Indonesia military_clash / deteriorating relations	NERAI indices OBS	Daily	Analyst-proposed: promote to priority area if a verified Natuna incident coincides with the series above 90.	Screening

Function	Implication tied to scenario and trigger	Action
Energy procurement (Asia-facing)	Under S1 Hormuz stays SEVERE through the 90-day window (ceasefire 3%); Chinese demand compression keeps Brent supported but caps the spike; Asian spot LNG remains the stressed market. One relief indicator is Hormuz recovery (transit above -50% for 10 days); diplomacy, policy and stocks also affect this.	Hedge Q4-Q1 LNG exposure; do not assume Chinese re-stocking before the recovery indicator fires; treat Iranian-origin barrels landed via Malaysia or Chinese STS as secondary-sanctions exposure (Hengli listed 24 Apr 2026).
China-linked manufacturing	Energy cost and policy pass-through rather than outages; export-control expansion priced at 80% by Sep 2027 is the larger supply risk; rare-earth flows to Japan already at zero.	Qualify non-Chinese magnet and heavy-rare-earth sources now; map Japan-China coercion exposure in Japanese-owned China plants.
Logistics (Asia-Europe, intra-Asia)	Malacca STRAINED (-11%) on bunker cost, SCS STRAINED on compliance/rerouting; S2 adds CCG-related routing advisories near Palawan and Scarborough; S3/S4 would hit the Taiwan Strait and SCS corridors, where NERAI's class-4 criterion (-25% for 7 days) is the operational trigger.	Pre-agree alternative routings east of the Philippines for S3; monitor corridor deviations daily; assess route-specific delays without treating a Cape diversion as a Hormuz bypass.
Insurance	JWC Hormuz listing 91% and formal carrier surcharges 86% imply war-risk pricing persists into 2027; an S2 casualty incident would likely trigger listed-area discussion for parts of the SCS.	Review additional-premium clauses for SCS calls; secure annual rather than voyage-by-voyage war-risk cover where exposure is recurring.
Supply-chain planning	GSCPI 0.805 SD (88th pctl, July) shows global stress easing from April's 1.84 while Asian corridors stay strained; the China-Philippines pathway is the one regional risk with both signal and event support inside 90 days.	Set inventory tolerances for Philippine- and Taiwan-origin inputs against the S2/S4 indicators; use NERAI's Decision Support Brief to convert these into order-by dates.
Compliance	Secondary-sanctions exposure of Chinese refiners, terminals (Qingdao Haiye) and traders has grown; MOFCOM blocking order creates conflicting-law risk for firms transacting with the five named buyers.	Screen counterparties against both OFAC Iran designations and the MOFCOM blocking list; document the conflict-of-laws position.

Country indices and shock model: indices.csv (29 Mar 2025-14 Sep 2026), shock_forecasts.json (13 Sep), regime_hmm.json (6 Sep) via MCP tools get_country_risk / compare_countries / get_early_warning, as-of 13 Sep 2026. Corridors: maritime_corridors.json (14 Sep) and get_maritime_corridors (7 Sep snapshot). Corridor ledger: foresight_ledger.json (entries 2 Jul-13 Sep). Forecast Desk: forecast_desk.json (review 15 Sep 2026; questions filed 27 Jul-17 Aug). Flashpoints: flashpoints.json (15 Sep; projection 20 Sep-11 Oct). Live AIS: chokepoint_ais.json (1 Oct 05:43 UTC). Themes: top_themes.json (1 Oct 07:31 UTC). Market layer: commodities.csv (to 14 Sep). Supply chain: get_supply_chain_risk (10 Sep). Calibration: mcp_snapshot meta.calibration (OOS ECE 1.1%, n = 118,300).

Hormuz chronology and status: Wikipedia "2026 Strait of Hormuz campaign" (events to 18 Jun); armedconflicts.org Hormuz crisis timeline (12-19 Jun MOU, 29 Sep tanker strikes); straits.live brief 20 Sep 2026 (8 transits on 13 Sep, 461 vessels holding, Ghailbaf statement); Gulf News 28 Sep 2026 (5 then 0 transits, Brent \$107.30, Trump rejects seven-day proposal, Saudi East-West pipeline); UANI Iran Shipping Update 29 Sep 2026 (STS transfers off Zhuhai 17 Sep and Hong Kong 22 Sep; 86 incidents, 24 deaths; 981 transits since 18 Jun). China energy: Columbia CGEP, 4 Mar 2026 (45-50% crude, 30% LNG via Hormuz; 1.39 bn bbl reserves); China-Global South Project / Reuters-Russell, 7 Sep 2026 (Aug seaborne imports 7.14 mb/d, Russia 1.68 mb/d, distillate exports 963 kb/d); OilPrice 14 May 2026 (30 Chinese vessels, Yuan Hua Hu); USCC "Enabling Iran" timeline (Iranian crude 785/823/534 kb/d; MOFCOM blocking order 2 May; ~60 designations; MANPADS and satellite reports). Summit: Al Jazeera 24 Sep 2026; Brookings, Sep 2026. South China Sea: USNI News 18 Sep 2026; SCMP 24 Jul 2026 (Wang Yi warning 22 Jul, Scarborough 23 Jul); Lowy Interpreter (11-12 Aug 2025 collision, US deployments). Taiwan: AEI China & Taiwan Update 1 Sep 2026; Daily Caller 14 Sep 2026 (MND counts 5-15 Sep); Modern Diplomacy 30 Sep 2026 (21 Sep purge). Korea: AEI Korean Peninsula Update 30 Sep 2026. Japan: Asia Times, Sep 2026; Wikipedia "2025-2026 China-Japan diplomatic crisis" (Jun-Sep 2026 entries). India: The Week 13 Sep 2026 (Modi-Xi, New Delhi). Selected sources are linked directly in this PDF.

Percentiles rank each series' 30-day mean against its own history since 29 Mar 2025; 30- and 90-day changes are differences in percentile; "x times" figures compare 30-day means. Shock probabilities are read against the platform base rates (4w 0.324, 9w 0.566, 13w 0.681). No NERA1 score was converted into a bilateral conflict probability. Scenario likelihoods are ordinal and labelled analyst judgement. Event classes follow section E. The counterfactual test in section F asks whether each tension would have developed without the Hormuz shock and assigns Hormuz one of four roles: driver, amplifier, constraint, unrelated.

Events after the September index cutoff are assessed through dated open sources. Taiwan and Vietnam use corridor, flashpoint and open-source layers. Original forecast values are retained as historical snapshots: their horizons run from issue dates, not from 1 October. Hengli's 69% forecast is historical only; OFAC listed the refinery on 24 April 2026. Lloyd's List Intelligence (30 September) records 117 non-Iranian-linked Hormuz transits for 14-20 September, indicating partial recovery within severe restrictions. Its vessel coverage differs from PortWatch and NERAL; counts are not interchangeable. Chinese military-support claims remain attributed media reporting. Country topic series share inputs; dyad attribution and statistical independence are not established.

K. Final synthesis

Direct answer

Which actor. On current evidence and NERAI's actual outputs, the Philippines is the neighbour with which China is most likely to experience a geopolitical crisis over the coming year. The judgement rests on two related NERAI series for each party sitting at their 18-month maxima simultaneously (Philippines military clash 100th, escalation 100th; China 99th and 95th), on a flashpoint dyad score rising while the US-China dyad falls, and on verified incidents on 23 July and 18 September 2026 that match the signal. Japan is the actor already in a class-1 coercion crisis with China, but its military series are falling; the Korean Peninsula is the region's fastest-rising military signal but China is not a party; the Taiwan Strait is the highest-consequence theatre but the lowest-signal one, with declining aerial pressure and a PLA command disruption that may constrain complex operations; India is screened out.

What form. Most plausibly a limited crisis (class 2 escalating to class 3): a coast-guard or maritime-militia incident at Scarborough Shoal, Second Thomas Shoal or off Palawan that produces casualties, followed by Philippine invocation of alliance consultations, US naval deployment and Chinese economic and maritime pressure. A blockade-type crisis (class 4) is the serious-escalation branch and is conditional on the limited crisis not being contained.

Time window. The 31-90-day window (1 November-30 December 2026) is the most defensible for the limited crisis, extending to six months; the basis is signal level and incident tempo plus analyst judgement, because no NERAI model predicts this event and the shock model places the Philippines series at base-rate jump risk. No date is offered. Managed tension without a casualty incident remains the single most likely overall outcome.

Hormuz's role. An amplifier through diverted US attention and a constraint on Beijing's bandwidth and economic room, not a driver: the China-Philippines, China-Japan and Korean dynamics would very likely have developed without the Hormuz shock, and the Taiwan link is narrative only.

What would change this assessment. A verified casualty incident (confirms S2 earlier); a second ramming within 30 days or a US-Philippine joint-resupply announcement (raises S3); the Philippines and China series falling below the 70th percentile for two weeks or the resumption of the bilateral consultative mechanism (returns to S1 with lower confidence in the actor ranking); a Taiwan Strait transit deviation below -10% or a named PLA joint exercise around the November votes (re-ranks Taiwan above the Philippines); and a US-Iran interim arrangement that lifts Hormuz above -50% for ten days (removes the amplifier and reopens US naval bandwidth for the Western Pacific). If the Indonesia signal is matched by a verified Natuna incident, Indonesia enters the priority set.

Confidence: moderate on the actor ranking, low-to-moderate on the window, low on causal attribution. Prepared by the NERAI Analyst Desk, 1 October 2026, from NERAI platform data and open sources to 30 September 2026.